

The Government and Private Synergy

- Article 21 A guarantees 'Right to Education' as a fundamental right. It states that 'the State shall provide free and compulsory education to all children of the age of six to fourteen years in such manner as the State may, by law, determine.
- The responsibility of providing education lies with the state and the government.
- However, government institutions at the primary and the high school levels are not synonymous with quality education. *You can bring in data from the board exams, compare the pass percentages of govt schools and private schools in Kohima, Mokokchung and Dimapur.*
- There is also an exponential increase in the number of private schools in these districts *(you can look at the last ten years – twenty years to see the number of new private schools, based on government data)*
- At the same time, there is a downsizing of government schools, closure of government schools.
- 'enrolment-poor" and "enrolment-heavy but resource-strained." – *(bring in data – you can compare the annual expenditure layout of a private high school and the annual expenditure of a government high school in a district, and distribute the expenditure per students, it will give a statistical data/hard number to bring in this perspective of 'enrolment poor - enrolment-heavy but resource-strained' dialectics/binary)*

The educational landscape of Nagaland currently stands at a historic inflection point. While the state has achieved a monumental ascent in literacy rates since its inception, it now faces a complex set of systemic challenges that threaten to undermine the socio-economic future of its youth. The duality of this situation is stark: on paper, Nagaland is a beacon of success, recently overtaking many larger states to become the third most literate state in India with a projected literacy rate of 95.7%. Yet, beneath these impressive statistics lies a critical "education paradox" where nearly 92% of the population lacks formal technical or vocational training, rendering thousands of graduates "degree heavy but skill light" and increasingly unemployable in a modern market economy. To navigate this crossroads, the Nagaland government and private educational stakeholders must transition from a model of isolated operation to one of profound collaboration, or "hands-holding."

The Nagaland Context: Enrolment Realities and the Case for Synergy

Nagaland's educational journey from a 21.9% literacy rate at the time of statehood in 1963 to nearly 96% today represents a social revolution. However, recent data from the Unified District Information System for Education Plus (UDISE+) suggests that the structural health of the public system is fragile. Student enrolment across Nagaland has fallen by over one lakh in the last decade, dropping from 5,30,177 in 2015–16 to 4,14,421 in 2024–25—a reduction of more than 21%.

Crucially, the burden of education is increasingly shifting toward the private sector. In the 2024–25 academic year, private schools accounted for 66.9% of total enrolment

(2,77,048 students), while government schools catered to only 33.1% (1,37,373 students). A decade ago, government schools held a 46% share, indicating a steady erosion of public enrolment in favour of private institutions.

The Crisis of Performance and Infrastructure in Government Schools

The call for "hands-holding" is underscored by a deepening crisis within the government school system, which has recently necessitated drastic administrative measures.

Zero Enrolment and School Closures

In January 2026, the Nagaland government ordered the closure of 34 government primary and middle schools effective from the 2026–27 academic session. These institutions, spread across districts including Kiphire, Wokha, and Zunheboto, were found to have zero enrollment or were entirely non-functional. Additionally, the State Level Education Committee (SLEC) has approved the merger of 17 other schools to optimize resource allocation and address teacher shortages in rural areas.

Dilapidated Infrastructure and Quality Gaps

The physical state of public schools remains a primary barrier to public trust. Of the 16,087 rooms in government schools, many are categorized as dilapidated or in need of major repair. In some instances, such as at Kezoma Urban Station, new buildings had to be constructed because old infrastructure was deemed "unfit for use and beyond renovation." Furthermore, the Central Nodal Officer (CNO) for PM SHRI schools recently flagged a "poor transition rate" from Class 9 to Class 10 and highlighted significant gaps in basic facilities, including laboratory infrastructure and toilets.

The Achievement Disparity

Examination results continue to highlight the performance gap between sectors. In the 2025 HSLC examinations, private schools recorded a passing rate of 87.64%, whereas government schools registered a modest 48.41%. While the state boasts a Pupil-Teacher Ratio (PTR) of 13:1—far better than the national average—the actual learning outcomes suggest that technical management flaws and infrastructure gaps continue to hinder public performance.

Enrolment & Performance in Nagaland	Government Schools	Private Schools
Enrolment Share (2024-25)	33.1%	66.9%
HSLC Pass Percentage (2025)	48.41%	87.64%
Enrolment Change (Decade)	-1,01,952	-15,354

Lessons from the "Aided" Systems of Kerala and Tamil Nadu

The most successful instances of "hands-holding" in India are found in states that have institutionalized models of state-supported private education.

The Kerala Paradigm: Stability Through State-Backed Staffing

Kerala's position as a leader in education is largely due to its "aided" sector—private-owned institutions where the government pays the salaries of teachers. In February 2026, the Kerala government moved to regularize nearly 20,000 aided school teachers, ensuring they receive full-service benefits. This fosters professional dignity and accountability, as these teachers are under the direct supervision of the state Education Department.

Tamil Nadu: Social Security and Grants-in-Aid

Tamil Nadu allocates 65.4% of its school education budget to teacher salaries, which includes staff in government-aided institutions. The state has also introduced special provident fund and gratuity schemes for aided schools. Under the Tamil Nadu Grant-in-Aid Code, the government provides impartial financial support to recognized private institutions to improve secular education standards.

The North-Eastern Blueprint of Assam, Mizoram, and Meghalaya

Assam: Provincialisation and the "Gurudakshina" Scheme

Assam has addressed its "Venture Educational Institutions"—schools established by local communities—through a phased "provincialisation" process. Since 2011, over 50,000 teachers have been brought under state management. In 2026, the government launched the "Gurudakshina" scheme to provide financial packages to venture school teachers who do not qualify for provincialisation, ensuring their contribution to literacy is honoured.

Mizoram: Community Partnership and Maintenance Grants

Mizoram utilizes its "Grant-in-Aid Rules" (updated in 2024 and 2025) to provide provisional adhoc and lumpsum grants for the general maintenance of private schools. The state also collaborates closely with the Young Mizo Association (YMA) to conduct household surveys and identify out-of-school children, leveraging civil society to achieve universal enrolment.

Meghalaya: Unified Grants and Private Sector Social Security

Meghalaya recently approved the "Meghalaya Non-Government School, Colleges Employees Centralised Provident Fund Scheme, 2026" to provide social security to private sector educators. Additionally, the state has entered into agreements with community groups, such as the Mothers' Union Tura, to manage government primary schools, proving that community-led "hands-holding" can revitalize failing institutions.

From Communitisation to Strategic Collaboration

Nagaland is uniquely positioned to lead this revolution because it already possesses the ideological foundation: Communitisation. The 2002 Act empowered Village Education Committees (VECs) to monitor schools and manage assets. However, current administrative friction—such as the ultimatum issued by the All Nagaland

Adhoc Teachers Group (ANATG) 2015 regarding pending regularisation—shows that the system requires a more structured approach to teacher welfare and governance.

Recommendations for "Hands-Holding" in Nagaland

Institutionalize a Grant-in-Aid Code: Move beyond ad-hoc support by creating a transparent framework for maintenance grants to private schools, modelled after Mizoram and Tamil Nadu.

Social Security for Private Teachers: Implement a centralized provident fund or "Gurudakshina" style package for private educators to reduce turnover and ensure quality instruction.

Lighthouse Complexes as PPP Hubs: Expand the NECTAR project's "Lighthouse School Complexes" to serve as resource-sharing hubs where private schools ("spoke schools") can access government-funded digital labs and specialized teacher training.

Vocational Integration: Partner with the 54 private colleges in the state to deliver the Nagaland Skill & Entrepreneurship Development Mission (NSEDMD), transforming degree-heavy institutions into skill-hubs.

Way forward

To our government stakeholders and private partners: the data is a clarion call. We cannot afford the luxury of parallel systems where one is "infrastructure-rich but enrolment-poor" and the other is "enrolment-heavy but resource-strained." "Hands-holding" is not an admission of government failure; it is a demonstration of government maturity.

By supporting private institutions with grants and teacher benefits, the state fulfils its constitutional mandate while leveraging the efficiency of the private sector. Let us evolve the "Communitisation" spirit of 2002 into a "Collaboration" spirit for 2026. Together, we can turn the "ticking time bomb" of unemployed graduates into a powerhouse of self-reliant Naga youth. The lighthouse is built; now let us ensure its light reaches every child, in every village, through a unified hand-in-hand effort.